Laura’s Story

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Laura's Story

Chapter 1: The Call



It was a bright, sunny afternoon. Laura was sitting on her front porch, sipping an iced tea and watching her neighbors go about their day. Some were mowing their lawns, while others were weeding their gardens or planting flowers. Children rode their bikes along the street, their laughter filling the air. Everything felt peaceful and relaxing.

Then Laura's phone rang.

"Hello?"

"Hi, Laura. It's me, Mary. I know it's been a while since we last talked."

Laura was surprised to hear from her friend.

"Oh my gosh! It has been a long time. How are you?"

Mary was happy to hear the excitement in Laura's voice.

"Listen, the reason I'm calling is that the girls and I want you to come with us on a five-day camping trip. Don't worry about the food or anything else. We've got it all taken care of. You

just need to say yes, pack your clothes, bathing suit, personal hygiene products, and a towel. Then all we'll need is you!"

Laura laughed.

"Really? Let me talk it over with my husband, Jason, before I say yes."

"It's in two weeks, so you have plenty of time to get ready. Call me as soon as you know whether you can come. I'm hoping you can! It's going to be a lot of fun. I just pray we don't get too much rain during those five days."

Laura smiled.

"Yes, I'll be praying for good weather too."

Mary sounded eager to end the call.

"Well, okay, dear. See you!"

Then the line went dead.

Mary never said goodbye anymore. Ever since losing her mother to cancer, she had struggled with the pain of her loss. The two of them had been incredibly close, more like sisters than mother and daughter.

Laura sat for a moment, thinking about her friend. Then she suddenly remembered something.

"Oh, shit! Jason will be home soon, and I haven't even started dinner!"

Just like that, Laura jumped up and hurried into the kitchen to prepare their evening meal.



Chapter 2: Laura and Jason's Relationship

Jason was so predictable. He was always on time for everything and was never late, except when he went out with Laura. She was always a few minutes late, no matter where they were going.

Jason tried to get Laura to be on time by lying to her about what time they needed to leave. It never worked. Laura could always see right through his little tricks.

This made it difficult for Jason to surprise her with romantic getaways, Christmas presents, birthday gifts, and anniversary surprises. To avoid giving himself away, he would keep himself busy and make himself scarce whenever he was planning something special. Laura simply played along, even though she knew he was up to something.

Then there was the time Jason planned a seven-day cruise to the Bahamas. Two weeks before the trip, Jason suddenly became difficult to find. Laura hardly saw him or even had a proper conversation with him. She knew he was planning something, but she had no idea what it was. When the day finally arrived, she discovered his surprise.

The cruise was amazing. They had a wonderful time sightseeing, walking along the beach, and swimming in the beautiful waters. The food was delicious, and they enjoyed spending time together.

Laura loved those moments with Jason. He was a great husband, and she appreciated the effort he put into making her happy.

There was just one thing she wished she could change.

Whenever Jason wanted to be intimate with her, Laura found herself wishing it didn't feel like a chore.

She loved Jason very much. He was handsome, hardworking, caring, and, in her eyes, the best husband a woman could ask for. She felt blessed to have him in her life.

She just wished she could enjoy being intimate with him as much as he seemed to enjoy being intimate with her.

Chapter 3: Their First Meeting



Laura and Jason had met at a singles club.

When Laura arrived that night, she saw her boyfriend kissing another woman. Hurt and angry, she turned to leave. In her haste, she ran straight into Jason.

When Jason saw that Laura was crying, he immediately tried to comfort her. That night, he became her hero. He held her, listened to her, and gave her the comfort she desperately needed.

What Laura didn't know was that Jason had also been hurt by his girlfriend.

The night before their wedding, Jason confessed the truth about their first meeting. He had gone to the singles club intending to hook up with a woman for the night. He wanted revenge against his girlfriend and hoped to make someone else feel the same heartbreak he had experienced.

But then he met Laura.

When she embraced him and he held her in his arms, something changed. He realized he didn't want anyone else. He wanted her.

Laura had changed his outlook on life that night, and from that moment on, they became inseparable.

Laura wasn't someone who turned heads because of her looks. She was a simple girl with sandy-

blonde hair and brown eyes. What she lacked in conventional beauty, she made up for with her personality. She had a beautiful smile and was warm, kind, genuine, and loving.

It didn't take Jason long to ask her to marry him.

Laura's family adored Jason, and his family loved Laura. From the outside, they seemed like the perfect couple.

But Laura felt pressured to marry Jason. It wasn't because she didn't love him, nor was it because she thought he wasn't handsome. The problem was something she couldn't bring herself to explain to anyone.

It all came down to intimacy.

At the beginning of their marriage, Laura told Jason she wasn't ready to have children. Jason wanted to make sure his career was financially secure before starting a family, too. They agreed to wait, and their families didn't pressure them.

But things had changed.

Jason had now made partner at the law firm, and suddenly, everyone seemed to think it was time for children. Laura felt the pressure from Jason, her own parents, and his parents. They all wanted children and grandchildren.

Her girlfriends were jealous of her. After all, Jason was a hunk. He worked out at the gym and always seemed to have a tan. He was incredibly handsome, and Laura was attracted to his looks. She just wished she didn't have to have sex with him.

It was a feeling she would never confess to anyone. The truth was that she was more physically attracted to women, something she had kept hidden deep inside herself.

Jason, meanwhile, seemed to be the perfect husband. He did the dishes, cooked, cleaned, and helped Laura with whatever she needed. He provided for her and made sure she had the things

she wanted and needed. In Laura's eyes, he was the best husband a woman could ask for.

They hardly ever fought or argued. They respected each other tremendously and believed in being honest, even when the truth was difficult to hear.

To everyone who knew them, they had a wonderful marriage.

But there was one truth Laura had never shared with her husband.

And it was a truth that would change both their lives.

Chapter 4: Jason Comes Home



Laura was in the kitchen, putting the finishing touches on dinner when Jason arrived home. He came up behind her, wrapped his arms around her in a big bear hug, kissed her cheek, and rested his head on her shoulder.

“That looks and smells delicious.”

Laura smiled. “It’s really simple and basic tonight.”

Jason grinned mischievously. “I wasn’t talking about dinner.”

As he untied her apron and began caressing her, Laura gently stopped him before things went any further.

“I’m really hungry, and I don’t want to have to reheat everything later. I promise I’ll give you my full attention after we eat.”

She kissed his cheek.

“Now, help me set the table.”

Jason sighed, but he began setting the table.

Once they were seated, he looked across at his wife.

“I really need some physical attention from you. Can we please have some intimacy tonight?”

Laura smiled reassuringly. “I promise. After we eat, clean up, and put the leftovers in the refrigerator.”

Jason looked down at his plate.

“You said exactly the same thing last night, and nothing happened. You just wanted to cuddle and go to sleep. What makes tonight any different?”

Laura's heart sank. She could hear the hurt and disappointment in his voice.

“I’m so sorry about last night.” She reached across the table and gently touched his arm. “I’ll make it up to you tonight. Which would you rather do? Clean up after dinner or prepare the bathroom for a romantic bath?”

“I’ll clean up,” Jason replied quickly. “That way, you can relax in the tub while you wait for me. I promise I won't take too long.”

He kissed her cheek and began clearing the table.

Laura was still sitting at the table when Jason looked over at her.

“Well, go on, then. Start running that bath!”

Laura smiled and rubbed his shoulder before heading upstairs to prepare their romantic evening. She began by running the water into their sunken bathtub. Then she added her favorite scented oil and lit several candles around the room.

After undressing in the master bedroom, she slipped into her robe and returned to the bathroom just in time to turn off the water before the tub overflowed.

She removed her robe and slowly lowered herself into the warm water. The soothing scent and warmth helped her relax, easing the tension from her mind and body.

Just as she was about to close her eyes, Jason appeared with a bottle of wine and two glasses.

He set them beside the tub before leaning over to admire his wife.

“You look beautiful,” he murmured.

He reached into the water and gently caressed her. Laura let out a soft sigh at his touch.

Just as Jason began to withdraw his hand, Laura caught him by the arm and pulled him towards her.

Caught completely off guard, Jason tumbled into the bathtub, landing on top of her fully clothed.

Laura burst out laughing at the expression on his face.

Jason was less amused about having his clothes soaked. But when he saw how hard Laura was laughing, he splashed a little water into her face.

Laura splashed him back.

Jason caught her hands and leaned in to kiss her passionately. Laura responded by wrapping her legs around his waist.

“Wait, love,” Jason said, gently freeing himself. “Let me get out of these wet clothes first!”

He climbed out of the tub while Laura continued laughing.

“You remind me of a cat that’s fallen into a bathtub and got soaked to the skin!”

Jason glanced at his wife as he struggled out of his wet clothes.

“I’m so glad you find this amusing.”

Then his expression softened.

“It’s been a while since we had fun like this. It’s also been a while since I’ve heard you laugh like that. This is exactly what we both needed tonight.”

Once he had changed out of his wet clothes, Jason poured a glass of chilled wine for each of them before climbing back into the bathtub.

They sipped their wine and talked pleasantly about their day.

Laura told him about Mary's phone call and the invitation to join the girls on a five-day camping trip.

Jason was delighted by the news.

“When is the trip?”

Laura was surprised by his enthusiasm, but she was happy, too.

“In two weeks.”

Jason smiled.

“Then we have plenty of time to make sure you're ready for this big adventure!”

He took their glasses and placed them safely on the floor beside the tub. Then he gently drew Laura onto his lap.

They began kissing, and the moment grew more intimate.

For Laura, it was easier to enjoy being close to Jason when they could laugh and share affection without the pressure of expectations. Yet, even during their intimate moments, a part of her remained disconnected.

They made love in the bathtub before moving to the bedroom.

Afterwards, Jason sensed that Laura was still unsatisfied. Wanting her to enjoy the experience, too, he continued to pleasure her until she reached climax.

For Jason, it had been a wonderful evening with his wife.

For Laura, it was more complicated. She was grateful for his tenderness and the effort he made to please her, but she still couldn't understand why intimacy with the man she loved could leave her feeling so emotionally distant.

Chapter 5: Laura Calls Mary



Laura was curled up in her favorite lounge chair on the patio, holding a cup of her favorite spiced tea.

She glanced at her phone with a mischievous grin before dialing Mary's number. Then she switched on the speaker so she could hear her friend's voice clearly.

A moment later, Mary answered.

“Hello, Laura! I hope you have good news for me!”

Thank goodness it wasn't a video call. If Mary could have seen her face, she would have known immediately that Laura was up to something.

Laura tried to keep the smile out of her voice. She was quite the actress when she wanted to be.

“Oh, I'm so sorry, Mary. I can't come with you and the girls after all. Jason is so busy with work, and he needs me at home.”

Mary sighed.

“Oh, I see.” Her voice sounded genuinely disappointed. “Well, the girls and I will be disappointed. Katie and Sarah were looking forward to seeing you, too.”

Laura couldn't take it any longer. Mary sounded so miserable that she was beginning to feel guilty.

“Mary, I was only joking!”

There was a brief silence.

Then Mary practically screamed with excitement.

“You dirty rat! You nearly had me in tears!”

She burst out laughing.

“You haven't changed a bit, Laura. You're still good at playing practical jokes! I'm so excited to tell the girls you're coming!”

And just like that, Mary ended the call.

Laura stared at her phone in disbelief.

“Wait a minute! What time are they coming to pick me up?”

She looked at the screen, but the call was already over.

Laura considered calling Mary back to ask, then decided against it. She would simply make sure she was ready early. That would certainly impress Jason. For once, she intended to be on time!

A smile spread across her face as another thought occurred to her.

“I just hope Jason doesn't start playing the same tricks Mary did, all to make sure I'm ready on time.”

She shook her head, amused by the possibility.

“I'm not telling him the truth. I'll just say they didn't give me a specific time, only that they'll be here somewhere between five and six in the morning.”

Satisfied with her plan, Laura took another sip of her tea.

She still had a week and a half to prepare for the five-day camping trip, and she was already looking forward to the adventure.

Little did she know that those five days would bring changes she could never have anticipated.

Chapter 6: The Girls Come to Fetch Laura



The day before the girls were due to collect Laura for their five-day camping trip, she began getting everything ready.

She searched through the closets, looking for something suitable to pack her clothes and personal hygiene products in. Eventually, she found Jason's duffel bag tucked away at the back of their closet.

Perfect!

It was big enough to hold almost everything she needed. All she would need was her small backpack for the remaining essentials, and she would be ready to go.

The following morning, Laura got up early. Since Mary hadn't given her an exact arrival time, she wanted to make sure she was ready whenever the girls showed up.

She was busy preparing breakfast when Jason walked into the kitchen.

“Wow! You're up early. You must be really excited about this camping adventure.”

Laura smiled. “Yes, I am. I know the girls will want to get the campsite set up early, so I don't want to make us late.”

Jason smiled and shook his head.

“Sometimes, dear, I wish you had that same attitude whenever we need to be somewhere on time.”

Laura lowered her head, feeling a little ashamed.

“I'm so sorry, honey. I never mean to upset you. I promise I'll try harder to be on time from now on.”

She leaned over and kissed his cheek.

Jason glanced at the bags beside her.

“Is that my duffel bag?”

Laura turned around with a smile.

“I found it at the back of our closet. You don't use it very often, so I thought you wouldn't mind if I borrowed it.”

Jason laughed softly.

“I've been looking for that thing for a while now! But I suppose I can survive without it for five days.”

Laura stepped forward and hugged him.

“Thank you, sweetheart.”

She kissed his cheek again.

“Breakfast is almost ready. There's coffee in the pot.”

Just then, they heard a car horn honking outside.

Laura hurried to the window to see whether the girls had arrived.

Sure enough, there they were!

Katie and Sarah were sitting in a pickup truck carrying a canoe and a two-person kayak. It looked as though they had packed most of the camping equipment, including tents and tarps.

Mary had arrived in her own car, which appeared to be loaded with food, blankets, and sleeping bags.

Laura turned from the window, excited.

“Honey, they're here!”

She grabbed her two bags and headed towards the front door.

“Wait!” Jason called after her. “You haven't had breakfast!”

He hurried after her, holding a slice of toast spread with strawberry jam.

Laura stopped just long enough for him to lean forward and kiss her gently on the lips. Then he placed the toast in her mouth and picked up one of her bags so she could eat while they walked outside.

The girls were so excited to see Laura that they immediately began waving and calling for her to hurry up and get into Mary's car.

Laura laughed at their enthusiasm.

Before leaving, she turned to Jason and took the bag from him. Then she gave him one last kiss.

Jason waved to the girls.

“Have fun, and make sure you all stay safe! I'll miss you loads, baby.”

Laura placed her bags in the back seat of Mary's car before turning to face her husband.

“I promise I'll be back in five days. I love you, and you stay safe, too!”

She blew him a kiss before climbing into the car.

The girls waved goodbye, tooted their horns, and called out excitedly as they prepared to leave.

Jason stood in the driveway, waving until the cars disappeared from view.

He was going to miss his wife over the next five days.

And Laura, excited about the adventure ahead, had no idea just how much those five days would change her life.

Chapter 7: Arriving at Camp



Sarah and Mary parked their vehicles beneath the shade of the trees.

Everyone began unpacking Sarah’s truck, getting the camping equipment ready.

They set up the tents and stretched an extra tarp over the picnic table so they would have somewhere dry to sit and eat if it rained.

Once everything was in place, the girls headed into the woods to look for dry wood to use for cooking. Mary and Laura went off together, while Sarah and Katie headed in the opposite direction.

As they gathered wood, Mary and Laura chatted about their lives. Every now and then, they could just make out the sound of Sarah and Katie talking somewhere nearby.

Before long, Mary and Laura had gathered a good-sized bundle of wood. They were making their way towards the sound of the other two women when Mary suddenly stopped in her tracks. Ahead of them, Sarah and Katie were kissing.

Mary dropped to her knees, letting the wood fall to the ground. When Laura caught up with her, Mary pressed a finger to her lips.

“Shhhh!”

She gently pulled Laura down beside her and pointed towards Sarah and Katie.

Laura stared at the two women, surprised by the feelings stirring inside her. Watching them kiss had awakened something within her, a warm, exciting sensation she couldn't quite explain.

But that feeling quickly faded when she heard the anger in Mary's voice.

“I thought those stories back in high school about the two of them being lovers were just rumors,” Mary whispered. “This is going to ruin our camping trip, Laura. I don't know about you, but I'm going to feel uncomfortable with them sharing a tent or even being together at all. Homosexuality is wrong. Don't you agree, Laura?”

Laura sighed. The excitement she'd felt moments earlier was now replaced by a sick feeling in the pit of her stomach.

“Sure, Mary. I agree. We'll keep them separated for the entire five days.”

Mary looked relieved.

“Thank you, Laura. I knew I could rely on you. We're going to have a great time together. I'm so glad you came with us. I can't imagine being here alone with the two of them. It would have ruined my trip.”

She reached over and hugged Laura.

As Mary stood up, she deliberately made enough noise to alert Sarah and Katie that they were no longer alone.

All four women returned to the campsite with the wood they had gathered.

Mary and Katie went to Mary's car to find something to eat. They decided on ham-and-cheese sandwiches with mayonnaise, accompanied by chips and soft drinks.

After lunch, the girls decided to explore the area. They followed a path down to the water, where a beautiful lake stretched out before them. They could see and hear the loons calling across the water.

Suddenly, Sarah spotted something leaping out of the lake.

“Look! A fish!”

Her excitement was contagious.

“I'm going to get my fishing pole. Does anyone else want to fish? I brought enough for everyone.”

Laura smiled.

“I'd love to go fishing.”

Sarah turned towards the others.

“Anyone else?”

Mary and Katie shook their heads.

Sarah started back towards the campsite, then glanced over her shoulder at Laura.

“I'll go and get our fishing gear. Are you all right with fishing from the shore? I'm a bit tired, and I don't feel like carrying the canoe down to the water.”

Laura smiled.

“I'm tired, too, after setting up camp and gathering all that wood. Fishing from the shore sounds perfect.”

Katie looked at Mary.

“How about you and I go for a hike in the woods? We can leave the fisherwomen to see if they can catch us some fish. Fresh fish on the grill would make a lovely lunch.”

Sarah turned around with an amused expression.

“Very funny, Katie! You're putting pressure on Laura and me to catch enough fish for everyone.”

Laura giggled.

“It's all right, Sarah. While you're getting the fishing gear, I'll pray that our Creator blesses us with enough fish for all of us.”

Mary laughed.

“If only my husband would pray before he goes fishing! Maybe then he'd come home with something to eat after his fishing trips. My husband isn't nearly as religious as I am.”

Katie looked at Sarah and Laura.

“Well, good luck to both of you. I really hope you catch enough fish for us to eat!”

With that, Mary and Katie set off to find a hiking trail.

Laura was left alone beside the lake, waiting for Sarah to return. As she gazed across the water, she felt a warm, fuzzy sensation at the thought of spending time alone with her.

What am I thinking? Laura scolded herself. *I'm being so stupid. Katie and Sarah are obviously together. Mary and I just caught them kissing!*

She shook her head, trying to put those thoughts aside.

A few minutes later, Sarah returned with two fishing rods and some bait.

The two women settled down along the shore and cast their lines into the water.

As luck would have it, they each caught two fish.

Laura and Sarah were delighted. With four fish between them, they had enough for everyone to enjoy a freshly cooked lunch.

They returned to the campsite, carrying their catch proudly.

Mary and Katie hadn't yet returned from their hike, so Sarah began cleaning the fish while Laura prepared the fire for grilling.

By the time Mary and Katie approached the campsite, the delicious smell of fish cooking over the fire was drifting through the air.

“Looks like we made it back just in time!” Mary exclaimed.

Katie laughed as they hurried over to see what was cooking.

Mary went to her car to fetch some plates and potato salad to accompany the fish.

Soon, everyone was sitting together, enjoying their meal and sharing stories about their afternoon. There was plenty of laughter, joking, and teasing as each woman recounted her adventures.

For the rest of the afternoon, they relaxed and enjoyed one another's company.

That evening, Katie prepared her famous beef stew for everyone. After a full day of setting up camp, gathering wood, fishing, and hiking, the girls were exhausted.

They decided to turn in early.

As Katie and Sarah headed towards one of the tents, Mary quickly called out to Sarah.

“Sarah, would you mind sleeping in my tent tonight? I haven't had much time to spend with you, and I'd like to talk about our plans for tomorrow. It won't take long.”

Sarah smiled.

“Sure, no problem.”

Before following Mary into the tent, she shot Katie a quick look.

Laura noticed the exchange and felt uneasy. She was going to be sharing a tent with Katie, and she remembered Mary's words about keeping Sarah and Katie separated for the remainder of the trip.

She tried to put the thought out of her mind as she and Katie settled into their tent.

Katie reached over and switched off the light.

“Good night, Laura. Sweet dreams.”

Laura managed a smile.

“Night, Katie. Same to you.”

Chapter 8: Day Two



Sarah was the first to wake up that morning. She started a pot of coffee and began cooking pancakes over the campfire.

Laura was the next to emerge from her tent. As she approached the fire, she saw Sarah expertly flipping a pancake.

“Wow, I'm impressed! The coffee and pancakes smell amazing out here in the fresh air.”

Sarah laughed.

“And here I was, thinking you were going to compliment me on my cooking!”

Laura giggled.

“Well, if they taste as good as they smell, then yes, I'll compliment your cooking!”

Sarah shook her head with a grin.

“Deal, I guess.”

She placed the freshly cooked pancake on a plate with the others.

Before long, Katie and Mary emerged from their tents. Laura was pouring coffee into four cups when the other two women hurried over to get their first cup of the day.

Mary took a sip and sighed happily.

“Oh, my goodness! This coffee is amazing. I love camping. Everything tastes so much better out here in the fresh air.”

Katie giggled.

“We haven't tried Sarah's pancakes yet. They might not taste so good!”

All the girls burst out laughing, except Sarah.

“Go ahead and make fun of me! Next time, someone else can cook breakfast and make the coffee!”

Katie looked at Sarah with a mischievous grin.

“Did someone forget to have her happy coffee this morning?”

Mary and Laura giggled.

Laura picked up Sarah's cup and carried it over to her.

“Sorry for teasing you so early in the morning. We really do appreciate you making breakfast for us. I'm sure your pancakes will be out-of-this-world delicious!”

Sarah accepted the coffee with a smile.

“Thank you.”

She continued cooking while Mary fetched plates and forks for everyone, and Katie brought out the butter and maple syrup.

Finally, breakfast was ready.

Mary, Laura, and Katie each took their first bite while Sarah watched their reactions expectantly.

In perfect unison, the three women exclaimed, “Wow! The best pancakes ever!”

Sarah smiled triumphantly.

“Very nice! But somebody else is still cooking breakfast tomorrow!”

Mary looked at the other two women.

“One of us will have to get up early tomorrow. Who's it going to be?”

Laura glanced at Katie, a devilish grin spreading across her face. Then she turned to Mary.

“Well, it looks like you're the one making breakfast for everyone tomorrow morning!”

Mary stared at her in disbelief.

“Me? Why me?”

Katie smiled innocently.

“Because you're a bit bossy!”

The girls burst out laughing, and even Mary joined in.

“Fair enough,” she admitted. “It's just that I'm so used to making all the decisions at home. My husband leaves everything up to me. I'm sorry if I've been too bossy.”

The other women immediately reassured her.

Laura stepped forward and gave Mary a hug. Then she whispered in her ear.

“Relax and let things flow. You don't have to be in control of everything here. Just enjoy yourself and have fun.”

She kissed Mary's cheek.

Mary blushed, then looked around at the others.

“How about we take the boats down to the water this morning?”

The girls burst out laughing again.

“You can't do it, can you, Mary?” they asked in unison.

Mary looked at them in complete innocence.

“Do what?”

The other women shook their heads, smiling.

Katie answered her.

“You really do have to be in control of everything! You know what? That's just who you are, and we accept you for it because we love you. We were just hoping you could relax a little during these five days.”

Mary sighed and lowered her head.

“I'm sorry. I'll really make an effort to relax for the rest of our stay. But I can't promise you anything. All I can do is try.”

Laura gently took Mary's hand.

“Let's just have fun and let things happen spontaneously, shall we? We'll eat when we're hungry, without anyone watching the clock. No more planning everything around what our watches tell us about when to eat, wake up, or even go to sleep. Deal?”

“Deal!” all the girls replied together.

Katie raised her hand.

“So, we're still taking the boats down to the lake this morning after breakfast, right?”

Everyone burst out laughing.

Sarah looked around at her friends.

“Hell, yeah! We're taking the boats down to the lake!”

The girls were now buzzing with excitement. They finished their breakfast and coffee before cleaning up their dishes and tidying the campsite.

With everything in order, they were ready to head down to the lake and begin another day of adventure.

As Laura lay in the darkness, she wondered how she was going to manage the next five days.

Chapter 9: The Lake



The girls headed over to Sarah's truck to unload the kayak and canoe. Mary and Katie carried the two-person kayak down to the lake, while Sarah and Laura took the canoe. When they reached the water, they stopped to admire the view.

The lake was breathtakingly beautiful. Its surface was perfectly still, without even a ripple. The sunlight danced across the water, reflecting the blue sky above. It was peaceful, picturesque, and inviting.

The girls carefully lowered their boats into the water and put on their life jackets before climbing aboard. Mary and Katie settled into the kayak, while Sarah and Laura took their places in the canoe.

Katie looked over at Sarah and Laura with a mischievous smile.

“Let's have a race! First boat to reach the other side of the lake wins!”

Sarah glanced across the water.

“You're on! Let's do it!”

They agreed to start paddling at the same time to keep the race fair.

The moment they set off, Mary and Katie pulled ahead. Sarah and Laura, however, were having trouble coordinating their paddling. Every time Sarah pushed her paddle into the water, Laura seemed to be working at a different rhythm.

It took them a while to find their rhythm, and by then, Mary and Katie had built up a considerable lead.

Laura wasn't happy about falling behind. Determined to catch up, she began paddling harder, plunging her paddle deep into the water with far too much enthusiasm.

The canoe started rocking violently.

Sarah struggled to keep it stable and slowed her paddling.

“Laura! What are you doing?”

But it was too late.

The canoe tipped, and both women tumbled into the lake.

Mary heard their screams and turned around. When she saw Sarah and Laura splashing about beside their overturned canoe, she and Katie burst out laughing.

Sarah, however, wasn't amused.

Laura looked at her apologetically.

“I'm so sorry! I was just trying to catch up with them. I guess I'm a bit competitive.”

Sarah splashed water at her.

“A bit competitive, my ass! You just don't like losing!”

She shook her head in disbelief.

“Now, you get our paddles while I turn this canoe over.”

Laura swam off to retrieve the paddles while Sarah worked on righting the canoe.

By the time Laura returned with the second paddle, Sarah was climbing back into the boat. Laura swam alongside and handed her the paddles before pulling herself over the side.

Meanwhile, Mary and Katie were still well ahead of them.

Sarah looked at Laura with renewed determination.

“Right! We're wet now, and those rotten scoundrels have taken advantage of our little accident. Let's go get them!”

Laura grinned and nodded.

This time, Sarah took charge of coordinating their paddling. She told Laura when to put her paddle into the water and when to pull it back, helping them move forward together.

Before long, they were closing the gap.

Katie was looking ahead when she suddenly spotted the tip of their canoe approaching.

She let out an ear-piercing scream.

The unexpected noise startled Mary so badly that she jumped and twisted around in her seat.

The kayak capsized.

Suddenly, Mary and Katie were both in the water!

Sarah and Laura couldn't help themselves. They burst out laughing as they watched their friends splash about beside the overturned kayak.

Mary was furious.

“What the hell, Katie?” she shouted as she struggled to keep herself afloat. “You are freaking crazy! The way you screamed, I thought Jaws was about to attack us—or that Jason was reaching

up from beneath the water to grab us, like in *Friday the 13th!*"

That only made Laura and Sarah laugh harder.

Katie tried to defend herself.

"In my defense, I never thought they'd catch up to us! I was completely surprised when I saw them!"

Mary glared at her.

"So, you scream like something is about to kill us? Seriously?"

Laura watched the two women arguing in the water. Neither seemed particularly interested in righting their kayak, and their paddles were floating farther away.

She called out to them.

"I strongly suggest you retrieve your paddles before they reach the shore without you! It's only a short distance now. We'll see you on shore!"

Katie slapped the water in frustration. She had been so certain they would win the race.

She turned towards the kayak and began trying to flip it upright while Mary struggled to swim after the drifting paddles.

Katie finally lost her patience.

"Do I have to do everything?"

Her words hurt Mary, who was already upset and struggling in the water.

"Forget the race! Let's just go back to camp. I'm wet, I'm hungry, and I've had enough!"

Mary's frustration was clear as she and Katie made their way back towards the campsite.

Sarah and Laura watched them go, feeling disappointed that their friends weren't going to join them for the rest of the outing.

Laura turned towards Sarah.

“They both said some hurtful things to each other. Hopefully, by the time they get back to camp, they'll have made up.”

Sarah smiled, although there was a hint of sadness in her expression.

“Katie's mouth is one of the reasons we aren't together. She says hurtful things to people. She'll apologize afterwards, but nothing ever changes. She just keeps hurting the people around her.”

Laura looked at her in surprise.

“I thought you and Katie were together. Mary and I saw the two of you kissing when we were gathering firewood.”

Sarah smiled knowingly.

“Oh, that explains why Mary arranged for us to sleep in separate tents. Thank you, Mary!”

She shook her head with a small laugh.

“I didn't want a big fight or to make anyone uncomfortable by telling Katie I didn't want her sharing my tent. She's the one who kissed me first.”

Sarah paused before continuing.

“Katie and I have a past, Laura, but I don't really want to get into it right now. I just want to enjoy the next three days.”

Sarah pulled the canoe closer to shore and found a shady spot where they could sit and rest.

Laura followed her and settled down beside her.

“I had no idea you and Katie were a couple back in high school. All those times you spent the night at my place, you never once mentioned being in a relationship with her.”

Laura paused, trying to remember something.

“I used to go on and on about that guy I had a crush on. Do you remember his name? For the life of me, I can't remember it!”

Sarah interrupted her with a grin.

“His name was Chris, and he was the captain of our school's football team.”

Laura stared at her in disbelief.

“How on earth do you remember that?”

Sarah leaned towards Laura, gently cupped her face in her hands, and kissed her passionately.

When she finally pulled away, she looked into Laura's eyes.

“I've wanted to do that for such a long time.”

Laura stared at her for a moment, surprised by the honesty in Sarah's words. Then she reached for the front of Sarah's wet shirt and pulled her closer, pressing her lips against Sarah's.

The kiss quickly deepened. Laura's feelings, which she had been trying so hard to dismiss, were no longer something she could ignore.

She began caressing Sarah, her hands moving over her body. Sarah paused for a moment, making sure they were completely alone and that Laura truly wanted to continue.

When Laura drew her close again, Sarah responded with equal affection.

There, beside the quiet lake, away from the others and the expectations of their everyday lives, the two women finally gave in to the feelings they had kept hidden.

They made love before eventually gathering their things and returning to the campsite.

When Sarah and Laura arrived back at the campsite, Katie was sitting beside the fire pit with Mary. Both women had changed into dry clothes and were enjoying a snack.

Katie looked up as the two women approached, a mischievous smile spreading across her face.

“Well, look who's finally decided to come back! I was beginning to wonder if you'd got lost exploring the lake.”

Sarah rolled her eyes.

“We weren't lost, Katie. We just took our time.”

“Of course, you did,” Katie replied, raising an eyebrow. “I'm sure you found plenty of interesting things to explore while you were out there.”

Laura glanced at Sarah, trying not to laugh.

Sarah gave Katie a warning look.

“Don't start, Katie.”

Katie held up her hands innocently.

“What? I haven't said anything!”

Mary looked between them, beginning to understand what Katie was hinting at. She smiled but decided not to get involved.

Sarah shook her head.

“Honestly, you never change.”

Katie called after her.

“That's what makes me so lovable!”

Sarah turned around briefly.

“That's debatable!”

Mary laughed before getting to her feet.

“Right, before you two start another argument, how about we get some lunch? I'm feeling a little tired after our little adventure in the lake. I think a good meal followed by an afternoon nap sounds like a wonderful idea.”

Katie nodded in agreement.

“I'm all for that. I think we've had enough excitement for one morning.”

Laura smiled.

“Lunch and a nap sound perfect to me.”

Sarah agreed, and the girls began preparing something to eat. They settled around the picnic table, enjoying their meal and chatting about the morning's events.

Katie gave Sarah another mischievous smile.

Before long, the campsite had grown quiet, with all four women settling down for a well-earned afternoon nap.

Chapter 10: Two Hours Later



Katie woke up and noticed that Laura was still sleeping. She turned slightly and studied her friend's face.

Laura wasn't conventionally beautiful, but there was something about her that Katie found particularly attractive. She had a natural beauty that didn't need anything added to it.

Katie had known for years that Sarah had the hots for Laura, ever since high school. She also knew that Sarah's feelings had never really gone away.

Katie sighed quietly.

She knew she wasn't always easy to get along with. No matter how hard she tried, she always seemed to mess things up. She knew she could be rude and say hurtful things, but she had never really made an effort to change.

That's just who I am. Why can't people accept me for who I am? Why do they expect me to be sweet all the time? Why couldn't I be more like you, Laura?

She looked at Laura again.

I love Sarah, and I want her to be happy. If that means giving her a chance with Laura, then that's what I'll do. I'm going to put the two of them together for the remainder of our stay here. And I know exactly how I'm going to do it.

Just then, Laura stretched her arms, yawned and slowly opened her eyes. She found Katie smiling at her.

"Did you have a good nap?" Katie asked.

Laura smiled.

"Yes, I did. Are the other girls awake yet?"

Katie unzipped the tent door and peered outside.

"No, I don't think so."

Laura gently nudged Katie out of the way.

"Sorry, I need to pee. Excuse me!"

Katie made her way over to Mary and Sarah's tent. Carefully unzipping the entrance, she peered inside to see whether they were still sleeping.

Sure enough, both women were fast asleep.

When Laura returned, Katie raised a finger to her lips.

"Sssshhhh!"

She wore a devilish grin.

Laura immediately started giggling and covered her mouth with her hand to stop herself from laughing.

Katie quietly went over to where their cooking equipment was kept and picked up a pot and a spoon. She then crept back towards Mary and Sarah's tent.

Without warning, she began banging the spoon against the pot as loudly as she could.

"WHAT THE HELL!" Sarah shouted from inside.

Mary quickly responded.

"Don't swear in my tent! What on earth is going on out there?"

Mary's head popped out of the tent. She was greeted by the sight of Laura and Katie laughing hysterically.

At first, Mary wasn't amused. But when she saw the two women practically rolling around on the ground, she couldn't help joining in.

Sarah eventually emerged, shaking her head.

"Just so you know what's coming, payback is a..."

She glanced at Mary before continuing.

"...is a saint!"

Mary turned towards her.

"Don't you mean a bitch?"

Sarah's mouth dropped open in disbelief.

"Well, yeah! But you said no swearing!"

Mary looked at her indignantly.

"Yes, but a freaking saint? Payback is a saint? That's just wrong, Sarah. It has to be a bitch!"

That was enough to set everyone off again.

It took several minutes before the laughter finally subsided and the women could wipe the tears from their eyes.

Katie looked around at everyone.

"It's almost three o'clock, and I'm getting hungry. How about a snack?"

Mary nodded.

"That sounds like a great idea. Let's all have a quick bite to eat, then take a short walk through the woods before dinner."

The others readily agreed.

By the time the girls returned from their walk, everyone was feeling tired. Mary suggested they heat up the leftovers and prepare some salads for dinner so nobody would have to cook.

Everyone thought that was a good idea.

After dinner, Sarah looked at the others.

"How about we go on an all-day hike tomorrow? I was looking over Katie's map and found a trail that looks like it could be a fun adventure."

Mary turned towards Katie and Laura.

"I'm in if you girls are."

Katie and Laura looked at each other before turning towards Sarah.

"We're in too!" they replied together.

Sarah smiled.

"Great! Then let's get an early night. We have lots to do in the morning. We'll need to pack food and drinks, first aid supplies and..."

Mary interrupted her.

"What we really need is a good breakfast before we go hiking tomorrow, followed by a good night's sleep."

Katie raised her hand.

"Speaking of a good night's sleep, no offence, Laura, but your snoring really disturbs me."

She glanced at Mary before continuing.

"Mary is right. We all need a good night's rest. I know Sarah can sleep through a train wreck, so,

Mary, if it's alright with you, could I switch tents with Sarah?"

Mary thought about it for a moment.

"Sure. I don't see any harm in that. Sarah, are you okay with sharing with Laura?"

Sarah looked at Katie, hardly believing what she had just arranged. She quickly recovered and smiled.

"Yeah, that's no problem at all. Agreed, Laura?"

Laura smiled.

"Agreed."

The women helped each other clean up after dinner before heading off to their respective tents.

Mary and Katie settled into one tent, while Sarah and Laura shared the other.

Katie lay back, quietly pleased with how things had turned out.

Her plan was beginning to fall into place.

Chapter 11: Day Three



When Laura and Sarah entered their tent together, neither made any attempt to touch or kiss the other. They were both exhausted and knew they had a long day ahead of them. Instead, they snuggled together, wrapped their arms around each other and soon drifted off to sleep.

The following morning, Mary was up early preparing breakfast. She had just put some water over the fire to heat for coffee when Laura and Sarah emerged from their tent.

Katie was the last to wake up.

As the girls enjoyed their bacon and eggs, they discussed what food and supplies they would need for their hike.

Sarah suggested that they distribute everything evenly between their backpacks so that nobody would have to carry more weight than anyone else.

Everyone agreed.

After finishing their breakfast and coffee, they began packing. They took plenty of water, granola bars, sandwiches, potato chips, trail mix containing nuts and dried fruit, and, of course, chocolate.

They also divided the first-aid supplies between them in case anyone got injured along the way.

It was a perfect day for hiking. The temperature was neither too hot nor too cold. A few clouds drifted across the sky, but the sun was shining brightly. The morning air was crisp and refreshing.

As they entered the woods, they were greeted by the strong scent of pine trees. Birds chirped happily, in the branches above them, filling the forest with their songs.

Suddenly, a red-tailed hawk screeched overhead as it searched for food. Further along the trail, t hey caught sight of several wild rabbits disappearing into the undergrowth.

Sarah whispered, almost to herself,

"I wish I had a camera."

Just then, a doe and her young fawn stepped into a clearing. Startled by the sight of the four women, the mother deer quickly darted away, with her youngster struggling to keep up.

Mary watched them disappear before turning towards the others.

"I sure hope we don't run into any bears or mountain lions."

Katie snickered.

"Boy, you really know how to ruin a moment! Here we are, four women wandering through the woods with nothing but food and first-aid supplies. Nobody thought to bring pepper spray or anything we could use as a weapon.

So, all we can do, Mary, is offer them our food and pray they'll accept it instead of deciding we're their lunch.

And secondly, nobody knows we're on this trail. So, let's just pray we don't get eaten and that we make it back to camp without getting lost!"

Mary looked at her in exasperation.

"Look who's talking about ruining a great day!"

Katie simply smiled.

"I was just stating the obvious."

Laura and Sarah couldn't help laughing.

Sarah looked at Katie, then turned towards Mary.

"You two are made for each other! How about we just concentrate on having a positive day and stop thinking about all the things that could go wrong?"

Mary sighed.

"Agreed."

Katie nodded in agreement.

The women continued along the trail until it began climbing a gentle slope. The path then turned left and gradually became steeper as it wound its way upwards.

Mary looked at Sarah.

"Are we going to climb a mountain?"

Sarah glanced at the others.

"Yes. According to the map, it has spectacular views from the top."

Katie muttered under her breath,

"Yeah, spectacular views of our deaths!"

Laura was close enough to hear her and immediately started laughing.

Katie shot her a dirty look.

Mary and Sarah, who hadn't heard Katie's remark, looked at Laura in confusion.

Mary asked,

"What's so funny?"

Laura shook her head.

"Nothing. I was just remembering something Katie said earlier. It suddenly struck me as funny again."

Sarah sighed.

"Please, can we just enjoy ourselves and stay positive?"

Katie wore a devilish grin.

"I'm positively certain we're all going to die!"

That was enough to set Laura, Katie and Mary off laughing again.

Sarah, however, wasn't amused.

"Can we please just enjoy the day together?"

Laura looked at her.

"You need to lighten up, Sarah. We're all laughing except you!"

Sarah lowered her head.

"You're right. I'm trying too hard to make this a great day. I'll relax now."

The women continued their climb until they finally reached the summit.

The views were absolutely breathtaking.

Far off in the distance, they could see a beautiful lake. Below them, an endless carpet of trees stretched across the landscape, making it appear as though the forest lay at their feet.

They stood for a while, taking in the magnificent scenery before finding a comfortable shaded spot to sit and enjoy their lunch.

For a while, nobody spoke. They simply ate and enjoyed the peaceful sounds of nature surrounding them.

Eventually, Sarah broke the silence.

"We need to start heading back down. The sun is beginning to set, and it'll become difficult to see the trail markers if we leave it too late. I suggest we get moving."

The girls quickly packed their remaining food, secured their backpacks and prepared for the journey down the mountain.

They made it back to the campsite just before dinner.

Exhausted, they collapsed into chairs or onto the ground, grateful to have somewhere to rest their aching legs.

Sarah looked around at everyone.

"Today was a great day, especially after I finally relaxed and started enjoying all the sights and sounds of nature."

Katie, sitting comfortably in her chair, nodded.

"It really was great. The highlight for me was the breathtaking view from the summit."

Mary, with her eyes closed, agreed.

"I totally agree with you, Katie."

Laura reached for her bottle of water.

"The whole day was amazing. We saw wildlife, heard wildlife, and, best of all, we didn't get lost or have anyone injured!"

Sarah suddenly stood up.

"I think this deserves a celebration!"

Katie looked at her curiously.

"What do you have in mind?"

Sarah walked over to her truck and returned carrying a cooler.

When she opened it, the girls could see an assortment of beers and wine coolers.

Their faces lit up, and they hurried over to choose their favorite drinks before returning to their seats.

Mary took a sip of her wine cooler and sighed contentedly.

"Ahhh! This is the perfect ending to a perfect day. You did good, Sarah. Cheers!"

All four women raised their drinks together.

"CHEERS!"

Everyone settled back, enjoying their drinks and reminiscing about the day's adventures.

Then Katie spoke up.

"I'm hungry! Who's cooking? Oh, yes, by the way, it's getting dark. We need firewood, otherwise nothing is going to get cooked!"

Mary looked over at her.

"You know what, Katie? You really are a buzz killer!"

The others burst out laughing.

Laura stood up.

"I'll go and get some firewood."

Sarah immediately chimed in.

"I'll help you, Laura."

Mary glanced over at Katie.

"Jeez, guys! Okay, I'll cook."

Katie smiled.

"Don't worry, Mary. I'll help you prepare everything."

Laura and Sarah walked away from the campsite together.

Once they were far enough away from the others, Sarah gently grabbed Laura's arm and pulled her towards her. Before Laura could say anything, Sarah leaned forward and kissed her passionately.

Laura eventually pulled away, smiling.

"We have all night, but we're losing the light. We still need to find some firewood!"

Sarah sighed.

"You're right."

Both women laughed before getting down to business.

They gathered as much dry wood as they could carry and headed back to camp.

To their relief, there was already a small supply of firewood waiting there, enough to get the cooking started.

The women spent the rest of the evening eating, drinking and enjoying each other's company before eventually retiring to their tents.

Once inside, Sarah wasted no time making it clear that she wanted to be close to Laura.

Laura leaned towards her and whispered,

"We can't be too loud. They're right over there."

She pointed towards the other tent.

Sarah whispered back with a mischievous smile.

"They've had plenty to drink. I doubt they'll hear a thing."

Laura laughed softly before moving closer and wrapping her arms around Sarah.

The two women kissed and began exploring their growing affection for one another. Their earlier hesitation had given way to a deeper sense of comfort and intimacy.

Before long, they had forgotten about everything outside their tent.

They made love, eventually falling asleep in each other's arms.

Chapter 12: Day Four



Laura was the first to wake up the following morning. Before leaving their tent, she leaned over and gently kissed Sarah on the cheek.

Sarah stirred slightly but remained asleep.

Laura quietly slipped outside and began preparing breakfast. She got the fire going and filled the kettle with water for coffee. After drinking so much the previous evening, she was desperate for a decent cup.

As she waited for the water to heat, she smiled to herself, remembering the night she and Sarah had shared.

She felt closer to Sarah than she had ever felt to her husband, Jason. With Sarah, there was a sense of completeness, an emotional connection she had never experienced in her marriage. Even

their physical intimacy was different. With Sarah, there was no emptiness afterwards, no feeling that something was missing.

She returned her attention to breakfast and began sautéing the vegetables.

Just then, Sarah emerged from their tent. She smiled when she saw Laura and walked over to her. Sarah leaned forward, intending to kiss her on the lips, but before she could, Katie poked her head out of the other tent.

"Is the coffee ready? My head is still spinning from last night!"

Laura laughed and reached for two cups. She poured in some hot water and began adding the coffee.

Sarah gently stopped her.

"I can do that. You finish cooking."

Sarah took over the coffee-making and prepared two more cups. She handed one to Katie and another to Laura.

Just as Sarah was about to take her first sip, Mary emerged from her tent.

"Oh, please tell me that's my cup of coffee! My head is aching."

Sarah smiled and handed her a cup.

Meanwhile, Laura served Katie and Sarah generous portions of the omelet she had prepared. She then fixed plates for herself and Mary.

The four women settled down to breakfast, eating quietly as they enjoyed their coffee.

Eventually, Sarah broke the silence.

"I feel like going fishing today. It's good for the body and soul, especially after our celebration last night!"

Mary shook her head.

"Maybe for you, but I'm thinking about taking it easy. Perhaps we could go down to the lake, have a swim and then lie in the sun. I could do with getting a little color on this pasty white body!"

Katie looked over at Mary.

"I'm with Mary. I totally agree. That's exactly what we should do!"

Laura looked around at the others.

"I think I'd like to go fishing too."

Sarah smiled.

"Then it's settled!"

After breakfast, the girls gathered their belongings and headed down to the lake.

Mary and Katie took their towels, sunscreen, drinking water and some snacks. Sarah and Laura loaded the canoe with their fishing equipment before paddling out onto the water.

The morning passed peacefully. The two women enjoyed the quiet surroundings, occasionally chatting as they cast their fishing lines.

Around lunchtime, Laura began feeling hungry.

"Is there anything to eat?"

Sarah smiled and reached into their supplies. She handed Laura a peanut butter and strawberry jam sandwich, along with a can of Coke.

"Here you go."

Laura took the sandwich.

"Perfect! I love this sandwich."

The two women enjoyed their lunch, taking their time and soaking up the sunshine.

Suddenly, Laura let out a scream.

Her fishing rod was being pulled violently towards the water, and she struggled to hold on.

Sarah immediately dropped her sandwich and grabbed the rod just before it disappeared over the side of the canoe.

"Hang on! You've got something!"

Sarah pulled back firmly to set the hook before beginning to reel in the line.

She glanced at Laura.

"It's big and heavy! And strong, too! Get the net, Laura!"

Laura quickly grabbed the net and moved towards the side of the canoe.

The fish was getting closer.

When it finally came into view, Sarah couldn't believe its size.

It was the biggest togue she had ever seen.

The two women worked together, carefully guiding the fish towards the canoe. After several attempts, they finally managed to scoop it into the boat.

Laura was absolutely thrilled.

She couldn't believe she had caught such a magnificent fish. She was equally grateful for Sarah's quick thinking and help in getting it aboard.

They continued fishing for a little while longer, and Sarah managed to catch a couple of smaller fish.

Eventually, they decided to call it a day and head back to camp.

As they paddled towards the shore, they noticed something unusual.

The beach was completely empty.

They had expected to find Mary and Katie still swimming or sunbathing, but there was no sign of either woman.

They dragged the canoe onto the beach, collected their fishing equipment and carried their catch back towards the campsite.

When they arrived, they were surprised to discover that the campsite was empty too.

Mary and Katie were nowhere to be seen.

With dinner approaching, there was little time to wonder where they had gone.

Laura started preparing the fire while Sarah set about cleaning the fish.

They worked together, getting everything ready for dinner.

Just as the fish was ready to go on the grill, they heard voices approaching.

It was Mary and Katie.

Mary arrived looking delighted.

"You won't believe what we found! We decided to do a little exploring."

She proudly held up a container filled with wild berries.

Sarah and Laura looked at the berries, and their mouths began to water.

Sarah reached out to grab one, but Mary quickly shut the lid.

"Wait until later! I'm going to make a really yummy dessert using the leftover pancake mix."

Katie walked over to the fire and looked down at the fish.

"Holy shit! That's a big one! Who caught that?"

Mary stepped closer to get a better look.

She was equally impressed by its size.

Sarah smiled proudly.

"Laura caught it! I helped by reeling it closer to the canoe, and then Laura and I worked together to get it into the boat."

Mary looked at Laura in surprise.

"Wow! Great job, girls!"

She held up the container of berries.

"These will make an excellent dessert to go with our fish tonight!"

Dinner turned out to be a real treat.

Mary used the leftover pancake mix to make a camp-style berry cobbler, which proved to be a big hit with everyone.

After eating, the four women settled around the campfire, sharing stories about their day's adventures and reminiscing about past experiences.

There was plenty of laughter, and nobody seemed particularly interested in going to bed.

As the evening drew to a close, they all agreed that they would love to do this again someday.

Eventually, they hugged each other goodnight before heading off to their tents.

Once inside, Laura and Sarah settled down together.

Neither said very much. They simply held each other close, enjoying the warmth and comfort of being together.

Both knew that tomorrow would be their last day at the campsite.

And neither was looking forward to it.

Chapter 13: Day Five



Katie was the first to wake up that morning. She started heating water for coffee before turning her attention to breakfast.

She took four slices of bread and cut a hole in the center of each one. After buttering both sides, she placed them in a frying pan.

Once one side was nicely toasted, she flipped the bread over to brown the other side. Then she carefully cracked an egg into the center of each slice, making sure the yolk settled neatly inside the hole.

She covered the frying pan with a lid and allowed the eggs to cook until the whites had set.

The delicious smell must have been enough to wake everyone because, before long, the other three women emerged from their tents.

Mary collected the mugs for coffee, Laura went to get the plates and cutlery, and Sarah gathered the coffee, sugar and milk.

Everyone moved quietly, each going about their morning routine.

There was an underlying sadness in the air. They all knew this was their last morning together at the campsite, and nobody seemed particularly eager to talk about going home.

As they sat down to eat, Mary took a bite of her breakfast.

"This is the best bird's nest I've ever had!"

Laura looked at her with a puzzled expression.

"What bird's nest?"

Katie glanced over at Laura and pointed towards her plate.

"This! It's called a bird's nest. The egg yolk sitting in the hole represents a baby bird."

Laura smiled.

"Well, it's delicious. This is my first time having it. I'll have to try making it for Jason."

As soon as she mentioned his name, Laura felt a sudden pang of sadness in her heart.

She glanced over at Sarah and noticed the same sadness reflected in her eyes.

Mary, sensing the awkwardness, quickly changed the subject.

"How about we pack everything up after breakfast and head down to the beach? We can go swimming and play some volleyball. I think we still have hamburgers and hotdogs left over, so we can have lunch together before heading home."

The girls simply nodded in agreement.

It was a particularly quiet morning at the campsite. Nobody seemed to have much to say as they packed their belongings and loaded everything back into the vehicles.

When everything was finally packed, Katie grabbed her towel and volleyball.

"Last one in the water has to cook lunch!"

With that, she took off running down the path towards the beach.

Mary shouted after her.

"Wait for me! I'm coming! I'm not cooking lunch!"

She laughed as she hurried after Katie.

That left Laura and Sarah alone.

Sarah picked up the cooler containing the hamburgers, hotdogs, soft drinks and bread rolls.

Before she could head down the path, Laura stopped her and gently placed a hand on hers.

"I'm sorry I mentioned Jason's name and making him breakfast. For the record, it hurt me too."

She paused, looking directly into Sarah's eyes.

"Just give me some time to tell Jason that I'm in love with you."

Laura gently raised her hand and caressed Sarah's cheek.

Sarah immediately put the cooler down and pulled Laura into a tight embrace.

The two women held each other before sharing a long, passionate kiss.

Eventually, Laura gently pulled away.

"This isn't the end for us, Sarah. It's our beginning. I'm going to see you and talk to you as often as I can. You just have to be patient with me.

"I'm going to hurt someone I love very deeply, and I hope you understand that."

Sarah sighed softly.

"Yes, of course I understand. I'll be right here waiting for you, Laura. I've always loved you. Even before your husband."

Laura wrapped her arms around Sarah's neck and whispered into her ear.

"I know. I loved you back then too."

She paused before continuing.

"My family, as you know, is still very much like Mary's. If you remember, they're not particularly accepting of people who are different. And it's not just my family I have to tell. I also have my in-laws to consider.

"So please understand my situation and be patient with me."

Laura wiped the tears from her own eyes before gently brushing the tears from Sarah's cheeks. Then she took Sarah's free hand.

"Come on. Let's go. Put some smiles on our faces. Let's enjoy ourselves and have some fun before we leave."

The two women picked up their belongings and made their way down the path towards the beach.

Katie and Mary were already in the water.

Katie spotted them approaching and shouted,

"Come on, Laura! Run, run! Before Sarah gets a chance to beat you into the water!"

Laura immediately took off running.

Sarah wasn't far behind.

Just as Laura reached the shallow water, Sarah caught up with her from behind, scooped her into her arms and carried her forward.

They both crashed into the water together!

When they finally stood up, Laura turned towards Sarah and splashed her.

"Why did you do that?"

Sarah laughed.

"Now I don't have to cook all by myself! We both got wet at the same time, which means you're helping me cook lunch later!"

Laura splashed her again.

"All you had to do was ask! I would have helped you!"

Sarah splashed her back.

"Where's the fun in that?"

Before long, the two women were splashing each other so enthusiastically that some of the water reached Mary and Katie.

That was all it took.

Now all four women were involved, laughing and splashing one another until they were completely worn out.

Eventually, they gave up and simply laughed at the ridiculousness of it all.

They spent the rest of the morning swimming and chatting in the water before drying off and enjoying a few games of volleyball.

Lunch was a relaxed affair, with everyone helping to prepare and serve the food.

Sadly, the afternoon eventually arrived, and it was time to say goodbye to their little holiday

retreat.

They loaded the remaining belongings into the vehicles and prepared for the journey home.

Sarah and Katie travelled together in Sarah's truck, as Katie lived close to Sarah's home.

Mary and Laura travelled together, since Mary's house was close to Laura's.

The journey passed quietly.

Eventually, Mary pulled up outside Laura's house.

Laura thanked her for the ride, gathered her belongings and stepped out of the vehicle.

Mary waved goodbye before driving away.

Laura stood outside her home for a moment, watching the vehicle disappear down the road.

Her holiday was over.

But something inside her had changed, and she knew there was no going back to the way things had been.

Chapter 14 – First Night Back Home



Laura was walking up the driveway when she saw Jason, her husband, standing in the doorway.

“Boy, have I missed you!”

He hurried towards her, wrapped his arms around her in a bear hug and began kissing her face and neck. When he leaned in to kiss her on the mouth, Laura gently pushed him away.

“I'm so very tired. I need a bath, and I'm hungry. Is there anything to eat?”

Jason felt hurt. He had missed Laura terribly and had imagined that she would be just as excited to see him. He hadn't expected this kind of response from his wife.

“Yeah, sure, honey. I've cooked us dinner. You go and have a bath or shower. Would you like a glass of wine with dinner?”

Laura kissed him on the cheek.

“No wine tonight. I'm really tired. I just want to sleep in my comfortable bed. I've been sleeping on the ground in a tent for five days. I just want to eat and sleep.”

Jason began to feel a little better. He hadn't really thought about Laura's sleeping arrangements during the holiday. Perhaps she was simply exhausted.

“Sure. You take your bath, and I'll wait so we can eat together. Then I'll give you a massage to ease your aches and pains and help you relax. You'll get a good night's sleep.”

Laura looked at him. Her response was sharper than she intended.

“I don't want a massage. I don't want to be touched. I just want to eat and sleep. That's it.”

She picked up her bags and headed upstairs to their bedroom.

Jason stood there, dumbfounded. He hadn't held his wife in five days. He hadn't even touched her in five days. All he wanted was to be close to her, but Laura didn't seem to want him anywhere near her.

After her bath, Laura put on her pajamas and wrapped her robe around herself before going downstairs.

When she entered the dining room, she stopped.

The candles were lit, the lights were dimmed, and the table had been set with their fine China. Instead of wine, Jason had provided sparkling juice. Two wine glasses stood beside the plates.

It was Jason's way of telling her how much he had missed her.

Laura walked over to the wall switch and turned on the light. Then she blew out the candles, removed the wine glasses and replaced them with ordinary drinking glasses.

When Jason came out of the kitchen carrying their food, he saw what she had done. His expression changed immediately.

“What the hell, Laura? I'm trying to show you how much I've missed you, and every single attempt I make gets shot down!”

He slammed the food down onto the table.

Laura could feel his hurt, but she was hurting too. She felt trapped between being a wife and being in love with Sarah. If she accepted her husband's affection, she felt as though she were betraying Sarah. If she rejected him, she was hurting Jason.

“I just don't want anything romantic tonight. I understand that you've missed me.”

Those words ignited an anger in Jason that Laura had never seen before.

“You understand? That I, your husband, have missed you? You understand?”

He stood staring at her. Laura could feel his anger, and it frightened her. She didn't move. She didn't dare say another word.

Jason tried to get a grip on his feelings. He had never been this angry with Laura in all their years of marriage.

“Alright. Let's calm down and just have dinner together. Tomorrow will be a better day.”

He grabbed his chair forcefully and sat down, his teeth clenched.

Laura quietly and gently took her seat.

Jason banged his fork against his plate with every bite. Laura's stomach was in knots, and she had lost her appetite. She knew that refusing to eat would only make the situation worse, so she forced herself to finish her meal.

When they were done, Jason cleared the table.

Laura quietly slipped away and went upstairs to their bedroom. She quickly climbed into bed.

When Jason came into the room, he went to the bathroom, brushed his teeth and got ready for bed. As he climbed in beside her, Laura's body tightened. She pretended to be asleep.

She was relieved when Jason didn't move towards her. He simply rolled onto his side, facing away from her.

Neither of them said another word.

Chapter 15 – The Next Morning



The next morning, Laura got up early and dressed for the day. She went downstairs to prepare breakfast.

She decided to make bird's nest eggs, just like Katie had made at the campsite. She hoped they would turn out just as good.

She was about to turn them over in the pan when Jason came up behind her, wrapped his arms around her waist and pulled her towards him.

Startled, Laura pushed him away.

That reaction fueled the anger he had been carrying since the night before.

Jason raised his hand as though he were going to slap her across the face. But when he saw the fear in her eyes and the way she flinched in anticipation of the blow, he stopped. His hand dropped.

Through clenched teeth, he said, “When I come home tonight, I expect my wife to behave like my wife! Are we crystal clear?”

Laura simply nodded.

Jason turned, grabbed his coat and briefcase, and stormed out of the house. The door slammed violently behind him.

Laura stood frozen for a moment. Then her legs gave way, and she crumpled to the floor, sobbing.

When she finally managed to pull herself together, she reached for her phone and called Sarah.

“Hello?”

When Sarah answered, she immediately noticed that something was wrong. Laura's voice was shaky and upset.

“I don't know what to do, Sarah. I've never seen this side of him before.”

Sarah was concerned.

“What happened, Laura?”

Laura's body began to shake again.

“He's so very angry. He almost hit me this morning. I don't know what to do, Sarah.”

Sarah didn't immediately know what to say. Then she heard the emotion in Laura's voice.

“Please, can I see you? I just need you right now.”

Sarah took a deep breath.

“Yeah, sure. Do you want me to come and get you?”

Laura began to calm down a little.

“I'll be at your house shortly. Just wait for me.”

Then she hung up.

When Laura rang the doorbell at Sarah's home, Sarah appeared almost immediately. The two women embraced in a tight hug.

Laura pushed Sarah gently back inside the house. Then she pulled her close and pressed her lips

against Sarah's in a desperate kiss. She closed the door behind them with her foot.

It didn't take long for their hands to find each other, touching and caressing through their clothes. Sarah began to undress Laura, guiding her gently towards the bedroom. Laura returned the gesture, helping Sarah out of her clothes as they made their way down the hallway.

Once inside the bedroom, Laura climbed backwards onto the bed, pulling Sarah down with her. For a while, there were no more questions, no explanations and no difficult decisions. There was only the comfort of being close to someone they loved.

Sarah kissed Laura tenderly, and Laura responded with an intensity that surprised them both. Their closeness grew into a passionate encounter, and the tension Laura had carried since leaving home finally began to ease.

Afterwards, they lay together, hardly moving. Laura gently rubbed Sarah's back while Sarah rested her head against Laura's chest.

“Wow. That was intense,” Sarah whispered.

Laura giggled softly.

“Yeah.”

Sarah moved slightly and looked at her.

“What just happened?”

Laura smiled.

“I just had the best freaking orgasm ever. Wait… two of the best orgasms ever!”

Sarah smiled back.

“It was my pleasure.”

Laura let out a long sigh.

“I don't know what to do.”

Sarah looked at her with concern.

“What do you mean?”

Laura turned towards her.

“He's never, ever been this angry with me before. I'm in love with you, Sarah. I don't know what to do. Help me.”

Sarah gently touched Laura's cheek.

“You're going to have to tell him how you feel about us.”

That was when Laura began to cry.

“I'm going to hurt him so badly. I've done nothing but push him away since I got home last night. This morning, he came close to hitting me, Sarah. Then, before he left, he threatened me. He wants his wife back, or else. He didn't actually say what the 'or else' meant, but I know what he was implying. When he stormed out and slammed the door, I felt like I was being torn in two.”

Sarah hugged her and wiped the tears from her eyes.

“You do what you think is best right now. I'm right here waiting for you.”

Laura kissed the top of Sarah's head.

“Thanks, sweetheart. Let me get him to calm down first.”

Sarah pulled back slightly. There was hurt in her voice.

“You mean you're going to have sex with him?”

Laura was already feeling pressured by Sarah's reaction.

“What exactly do you want me to do? Piss him off even more, so that he hits me? Or possibly rapes me?”

Sarah's expression changed. She was upset, and the conversation had become more than she could bear.

“You go and figure this out on your own. Don't come back until you do.”

She climbed out of bed and began picking up their clothes. She handed Laura her things before going into the bathroom to get dressed.

As she left the bedroom, she said, “Please be gone by the time I come out of the bathroom.”

Laura dressed quietly and left.

Chapter 16 – Jason Comes Home



When Jason came home that evening, he had a bunch of flowers for Laura.

He felt terrible about the way he had behaved towards his wife that morning.

As he opened the front door, he heard soft music playing. He walked towards the dining room and noticed that candles had been lit. A bottle of wine was chilling in an ice bucket, and a delicious, savory aroma was coming from the kitchen.

He found Laura standing at the stove, stirring something in a saucepan.

“I'm home, sweetheart.”

Laura turned around.

“I'm so sorry for my behavior. I don't know what got into me.”

He held out the flowers.

Laura didn't even take them. Instead, she threw her arms around his neck and hugged him tightly.

When Jason gently pulled back so he could kiss her, he noticed the tears in her eyes. He reached up and wiped them away.

“You never told me how your camping trip was. I'm such an asshole. All I could think about was making love to my wife because I'd missed you so much. Then, when you treated me so coldly, it

really hurt.”

He paused, looking into her eyes.

“I realized just how much I love you. The thought of losing you… I just snapped. I'm not even sure, why I thought you might leave me. Your husband is crazy. You went on a camping trip with three other women. Why did I think there was someone else? That's how crazy your husband is.”

He hugged her again and leaned in to kiss her.

At first, Laura wanted to push him away. But when she felt his mood beginning to change, she quickly pulled him towards her and kissed him passionately.

Before long, the food on the stove had been forgotten. Laura switched off the burner, and Jason put the flowers on the counter. They began undressing each other, their kisses becoming increasingly passionate.

Jason lifted Laura into his arms and carried her to the sofa. He laid her down gently, kissing and caressing her. As he became more intimate with her, Laura closed her eyes and imagined it was Sarah who was holding her, kissing her and making love to her.

Jason was caught up in the moment, believing that his wife was finally responding to him as she once had.

They made love on the sofa. It was the most passionate encounter they had ever shared during their marriage.

Afterwards, Laura reheated their dinner. They sat down together and ate in silence.

When they had finished, Laura cleared the table and cleaned the kitchen. Jason went upstairs to take a bath.

When he came out of the bathroom, he was already thinking about spending more time with his

wife. He lit some candles in the bedroom and prepared the room for another romantic encounter.

When Laura walked in and saw what he had done, her first instinct was to refuse. She didn't want to be intimate again. But the memory of his anger was still fresh in her mind, and she was afraid of provoking another outburst.

So, she went along with it.

This time, however, Laura wasn't fully present. Jason was enjoying the closeness, believing that everything between them was finally getting back to normal. When he reached for her again afterwards, hoping to continue their intimacy, she turned away and made it clear she didn't want any more.

Jason was initially disappointed, but he decided not to make an issue of it. He had been intimate with his wife twice that evening, and he was satisfied.

He kissed Laura on the head and moved closer, intending to cuddle her as he always did after making love.

Laura immediately got out of bed.

“I forgot to lock the door downstairs. I'll be back in a minute.”

Jason simply nodded and settled back against his pillow.

Laura went downstairs. She knew perfectly well that she had locked the door. She had no intention of going back upstairs just yet.

She sat in her favorite chair and began to cry.

Chapter 17 – Jason Wakes Up



When Jason woke the following morning, Laura's side of the bed was still exactly as it had been when he closed his eyes.

He had expected her to return during the night. While waiting for her, he got dressed for work.

As he came downstairs, he noticed Laura lying in her favorite chair.

He hurried over to check on her. When he got closer, he realized she was simply asleep.

His blood began to boil again. She had refused to return to bed and spend the night beside him.

He gently woke her.

“Why didn't you come back to bed?”

Laura sensed the anger in his voice.

“I'm sorry. I sat down for a minute, and I must have fallen asleep.”

Jason's anger quickly subsided at her explanation. He leaned down and kissed her head. He could feel her body tense, but he kissed her anyway.

Then he grabbed his coat and briefcase.

“I'm going to be late for work. I'll be home late for dinner.”

With that, he left the house.

Laura began to cry.

For the next two weeks, she did everything she could to keep the peace between them. She tried to avoid anything that might upset Jason or bring back the anger she had seen in him.

She thought that if she did everything right, he would eventually return to being the gentle, loving man, she knew and loved.

But that man had yet to return.

The anger was still there, just beneath the surface. Laura could feel it, even when Jason wasn't

saying anything.

Somewhere in her heart, she suspected that Jason knew there was someone else.

And she was beginning to realize that no matter how hard she tried, she couldn't make things go back to the way they had been.

Chapter 18 – Laura Visits Sarah



Laura rang the doorbell at Sarah's house.

When Sarah opened the door, Laura immediately burst into tears.

“I can't do this anymore. I miss you. I love you. I need you. I thought that by being nice to Jason, he would become less angry. But he hasn't. It's as though somewhere deep inside him, he knows.

“He knows there's someone else. I'm in love with someone else, Sarah. That someone is you. I don't have the strength to tell him. I need to know that I still have you. That you still want me in your life.”

Sarah reached for Laura, pulled her inside and closed the door.

Laura turned towards her and kissed her passionately on the lips.

Sarah whispered, “I've missed you. I thought you'd chosen to stay with your husband.”

Laura smiled sadly.

“Every time we make love, I imagine it's you. Lately, I can't even make love to him because it's not you. I don't want to imagine anymore, Sarah. I want it too always be you.”

Sarah pulled her closer, wanting to make love to her. But Laura gently pushed her away.

“I'm going to tell Jason the truth. I'm going to tell him how I feel about you. I'm going to tell him I don't want to be married to him anymore. I'm going to tell him everything.”

Sarah looked at her, understanding that Laura had finally reached a decision.

Laura turned towards the door, ready to leave.

Sarah caught her hand and pulled her close for one last kiss.

“I'm right here waiting for you. With arms wide open.”

Laura smiled and nodded.

Sarah stood at the doorway, watching Laura walk away.

Chapter 19 – Laura's Suicide Letter



Laura was tired.

She was tired of trying to calm Jason's anger. Tired of living with the constant threat of violence, whether through his words, his actions or simply the way he carried himself when he was upset. The stress was becoming unbearable.

All she wanted was to end the marriage and be with the person who made her feel complete. She was tired of feeling lonely.

She had come to realize that sharing a bed with someone didn't necessarily mean you weren't lonely. You could lie beside another person every night and still feel completely alone when there was no real emotional connection.

Laura loved Jason, but she wasn't in love with him. Perhaps she never really had been. She had tried. She really had tried.

There was a difference, at least in Laura's mind, between loving someone and being in love with someone.

When you were in love, you felt connected to another person in a way that went beyond simply

sharing a home or a life. Their happiness mattered to you. Their sadness affected you. When they were hurting, you felt their pain too. You wanted to share everything with them, not because you were expected to, but because you genuinely wanted to.

Jason was in love with Laura. She was his whole world. But Laura didn't feel that same connection towards him.

For her, so much of marriage had become an obligation. She was expected to cook, clean, have children and make love to her husband because that was what wives were supposed to do. She had spent years trying to fulfil those expectations, believing that eventually everything would fall into place.

But it hadn't.

She knew Jason loved her. She could see how much he wanted their marriage to work. She even felt sorry for him. But sympathy and guilt couldn't create the love he wanted from her.

Laura wanted to be free from the nightmare she was living.

She was frightened that if she told Jason the truth, he might physically hurt her. Then there was the thought of facing her family, who were deeply prejudiced against homosexual people. She knew the things they would say and the way they would look at her. She feared their rejection almost as much as she feared Jason's anger.

And then there was Mary.

How would she react when she discovered what had happened between Sarah and Laura during the camping trip? Laura could already imagine Mary's horror at the thought of the two of them making love so close to the other tent. After all, Mary had separated Sarah and Katie because she didn't want them sharing a tent.

Katie was different. Laura and Sarah both suspected that Katie had invented the story about

Laura snoring so that she and Sarah could share a tent and have some time alone together.

Laura couldn't understand why people found it so difficult to accept that love was love. Whether it was between two men, two women or a man and a woman, surely the feelings were the same. People spoke about loving their neighbors as themselves, yet so many were willing to condemn others simply because they loved differently.

She thought about God and the beliefs she had been raised with. For so long, she had believed there was something wrong with her. Now she questioned why something as natural as loving another person should make her feel ashamed.

With tears running down her cheeks, Laura sat down and began writing a letter to Jason.

She wanted him to understand. She wanted him to know that she had never intended to hurt him.

Dear beloved Jason,

I'm sorry I have hurt you and caused you so much pain over these past few weeks. It was never my intention.

You are a terrific husband and provider. You have been gentle, loving, caring and supportive. You are everything many women would dream of having in a husband.

I'm sorry I haven't been honest with you all these years.

I felt trapped by you and by our families. My family hates homosexuality, and so does yours. You have never accepted it either. You believe it goes against God.

For the longest time, I felt the same way. I believed there was something wrong with me. I tried so hard to be the woman everyone expected me to be.

I married you because you were the ideal man. I thought that if I married someone as wonderful as you, everything would eventually feel right.

But something was always missing.

These past few weeks have been hell for me. I'm constantly afraid of your anger, so I do everything I can to keep the peace between us. I don't know how much longer I can live like this.

During the camping trip, Sarah and I finally confessed our true feelings for each other.

I tried so hard to play the straight role, Jason. I did it because I didn't want to disappoint my family or bring shame upon them. I hid my feelings from Sarah for so long because I was afraid of what would happen if anyone found out.

What happened during the camping trip wasn't planned. Things just happened unexpectedly.

You know Mary. She's very much like you and our families when it comes to these things. On our first night in the woods, she caught Sarah and Katie kissing and separated them. I ended up sharing a tent with Katie, while Mary shared with Sarah.

I swear to you, Jason, none of it was planned.

Yes, I cheated on you with Sarah. I know that, and I won't pretend otherwise. I think you already suspected there was someone else, and perhaps that's why your anger has become so intense.

I can't go on like this anymore.

I don't feel safe telling you the truth, and I don't want to endure the verbal and physical abuse I fear will come from my parents once they discover that their daughter is a lesbian.

Everyone says the Bible teaches that homosexuality is a sin against God. But I have searched the Scriptures myself, and I have found passages that make me question what people have always told me.

In Matthew 19:11–12, Jesus speaks about eunuchs. This is how the passage reads:

But he said unto them, All men cannot receive this saying, save they to whom it is given.

For there are some eunuchs, which were so born from their mother's womb: and there are some eunuchs, which were made eunuchs of men: and there be eunuchs, which have made themselves

eunuchs for the kingdom of heaven's sake. He that is able to receive it, let him receive it.

My understanding of this passage is that Jesus recognizes that people are not all the same. Some are born differently, some are made that way by others, and some choose a life without sexual relationships for their faith.

I believe Jesus was telling people that there are differences among us, and that we should not condemn someone simply because they are different.

I wish we lived in a society where there was no discrimination. Where people simply loved one another and accepted each other as God accepts us.

I really do love you, Jason. I hope one day you find someone who completes you, someone who loves you as deeply as you love them.

Please forgive me for what I've done. I hope God will forgive me too.

Sincerely,

Laura

Laura placed the letter on the dining room table.

She read it one last time, her tears falling onto the paper. There were so many things she wished she could say to Jason face to face, but fear had taken away her ability to imagine that conversation ending safely.

She thought about Sarah. She thought about the life they might have shared if the world had been kinder and if she had found the courage to be honest sooner.

Then she went upstairs.

She ran a warm bath and added lavender, hoping the familiar fragrance would calm her troubled mind.

For a long time, she sat alone with her thoughts.

The house was quiet. The letter remained downstairs on the dining room table, waiting for Jason to find it.

Laura had reached a point where she could no longer see a way forward. In her despair, she made a final, tragic decision.

And downstairs, the letter waited.

Chapter 20 – Jason Finds the Letter



Jason came home from work as he did every evening. But the moment he stepped through the front door, something felt wrong.

There was no familiar smell of dinner cooking in the kitchen. The house was unusually quiet, almost unnaturally so. He stood for a moment, listening, expecting to hear Laura moving around upstairs or calling out to let him know she was home.

Nothing.

He walked into the dining room and noticed a letter lying on the table. His name was written on the envelope.

He picked it up, opened it and began to read.

At first, he didn't understand what he was looking at. Then the meaning of Laura's words began to sink in. His expression changed, and anger rose inside him.

"LAURA!" he shouted.

There was no answer.

He continued reading, his grip tightening around the pages. The words seemed impossible to accept. He felt betrayed, humiliated and furious. He wanted answers. He wanted Laura to explain herself.

"LAURA!"

He hurried upstairs, his footsteps heavy against the floor. He reached the bedroom and threw the door open.

"Laura!"

The room was empty.

His anger was now mixed with confusion. He turned towards the bathroom and pushed the door open.

Then he saw her.

Laura was lying motionless in the bathtub.

For a moment, Jason couldn't comprehend what he was seeing. The anger disappeared, replaced by absolute horror.

"No! Laura!"

He rushed to her side, calling her name as he tried to find a pulse. There was none. He attempted CPR, desperately hoping he could bring her back, but she remained unresponsive.

With shaking hands, he pulled his phone from his pocket and dialed 911.

"My wife has committed suicide!" he cried. "She's not breathing. There's no pulse. I've tried CPR. Please, you have to help her!"

He struggled to listen as the dispatcher spoke.

"We're on our way. Stay with her. Help is coming."

But Jason knew something was terribly wrong. He continued trying to help her until he could do

no more. Then he gathered her into his arms and sobbed, holding her as though he could somehow keep her there.

When the emergency services arrived, they took over. They gently moved Jason away from Laura so they could attend to her. Despite their efforts, there was nothing more they could do.

One of the responders helped Jason downstairs while the police began asking questions.

"Did your wife leave a suicide note?"

Jason looked towards the dining room.

"There's a letter on the table. I found it when I came home."

"Have you read it?"

"I started reading it," he replied, his voice breaking. "But I didn't finish it."

An officer explained that they would need to take the letter as evidence while they investigated what had happened.

They asked Jason when he had arrived home and whether anyone could confirm the time. They also asked if he knew of anything that might have led Laura to take her own life.

Jason struggled to answer. His thoughts were scattered, and he couldn't make sense of what had happened. Only minutes earlier, he had been angry with his wife. Now she was gone.

As the police and ambulance prepared to leave with Laura's body, Jason approached the officer who had spoken to him.

"Can I have the letter back when you're finished with it?" he asked. "I didn't get to read all of it."

The officer nodded.

"Once the investigation is closed, we can arrange for it to be returned to you."

Jason watched as they carried Laura away.

He stood in the doorway, unable to move, knowing that the woman he had expected to welcome

him home that evening would never do so again.

And the letter that might explain why was no longer in his hands.

Chapter 21 – Two Years Later



Two years had passed since Laura's death.

Jason had remarried. His new wife, Susan, was a beautiful woman, and together they had found a happiness he had once thought impossible.

Jason had come to realize that Laura had been right about many things. With Susan, he experienced a deeper connection, one that went beyond what he had understood marriage to be. He loved her, and he knew she loved him. Their relationship was built on mutual understanding, affection and respect.

Susan was now expecting their first child, and Jason had never been happier. He had once believed that what he shared with Laura was special, but with Susan, he had discovered something even deeper.

Today, however, was Laura's death anniversary.

The police had kept their promise and returned Laura's letter to him once the investigation was closed. He had kept it safe, knowing that one day he would read every word she had written.

Sitting quietly, he unfolded the pages and began reading Laura's final thoughts. As the words came back to him, tears began to roll down his cheeks.

When he finished, he folded the letter carefully and placed it in his pocket.

He got into his car and drove to the cemetery where Laura was buried.

Standing before her grave, he looked down at the beautiful plaque he had placed there.

My beloved wife, Laura Ann Murphy. May you rest in peace.

He placed a fresh arrangement of flowers on the grave and stood silently for a moment. Then he took the letter from his pocket and placed it beside the stone.

"I'm so sorry, Laura. I'm sorry for my anger and for making you feel unsafe. I blame myself for what happened to you. The truth is, I was so angry that I could have killed someone with my bare hands.

"I didn't know how to deal with what you were telling me. How could I compete with another woman? The thought of losing you to a woman was so painful. The idea that a woman could give you something I couldn't made me feel inadequate. It drove me crazy.

"That passage in the Bible you wrote about... I'm still having a hard time digesting it. But I've come to realize something. Perhaps Jesus understood more than we gave him credit for. Perhaps it is we men who have made homosexuality a problem because of our pride and our egos.

"Our parents were so excited about having grandchildren. They wanted to brag to their friends and families. I see other parents doing the same thing, always comparing their children and celebrating what they consider their achievements. So much of it comes down to pride and ego.

"Perhaps that is one of the things that keeps us from understanding God's love.

"Your death wasn't for nothing, Laura. You slowly opened my eyes and my heart. If any of my children are gay, I will accept them and love them exactly as they are.

"God makes no mistakes. God is perfect. It is we human beings who need to grow and mature spiritually, so that we can become more like Christ.

"I wish I had understood that when you were still here."

Jason wiped the tears from his eyes. He looked at Laura's grave one last time before turning and

walking back towards his car.

He never noticed that someone had been watching him from a distance.

Sarah had seen him arrive. She had stood quietly, giving him the privacy to say whatever he needed to say to Laura.

Once Jason had driven away, Sarah approached the grave carrying her own flowers. She placed them beside Jason's arrangement and looked down at the plaque.

Then she noticed the letter lying beside the stone.

She picked it up and saw that it was addressed to Jason. At first, she intended to put it back without reading it. It wasn't meant for her.

But something stopped her.

She carefully opened the letter and began to read.

As the words unfolded before her, tears filled her eyes.

Laura had told Jason the truth. She had told him that she was in love with Sarah. She had wanted to be honest, to live openly and to love without hiding. But she had felt surrounded by people who would not accept her: two families and a husband whose anger had made her afraid.

Sarah had always known that Laura was struggling, but reading those words brought home just how alone Laura had felt.

She wiped her tears and looked towards the sky.

"Please, God, forgive Laura for what she did. Please, God, help us to love and accept one another. Help us, Lord, not to discriminate against or hate each other because of our differences.

"Teach us to love one another as You love each and every one of us.

"Amen."

Sarah gently folded the letter and held it against her chest.

For a long moment, she stood beside Laura's grave, surrounded by the flowers left by two people whose lives had been changed by loving her.

Then she placed the letter carefully beside the plaque.